

Gold Mining in 19th-Century Joseon within the Global Political Economy:
In Relations to the Gold Standard Debate in the United States

Jeeye Song

This paper explores the intersection between gold mining in 19th-century Joseon Korea and the debate surrounding the gold standard in the United States during the same period. As Joseon began to open up to foreign influence, its natural resources, particularly gold, attracted the attention of foreign powers and investors. The growth of gold mining in Joseon during the late 19th century coincided with the United States' internal debate over continuing the gold standard or adopting bimetallism (using both gold and silver) as the basis of its monetary system. This study examines how global economic trends, particularly the demand for gold as a stable currency reserve, influenced foreign interests in Joseon's gold mining industry. It also investigates how the exploitation of Joseon's gold reserves became entangled with larger geopolitical dynamics, including imperial interests from Japan and Western nations. By analyzing archival records including Horace Newton Allen papers at the New York Public Library, the article sheds light on the role of gold mining in Joseon within the broader context of global political economy, the rise of industrial capitalism, and the imperial ambitions of the late 19th century.